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Culture (OWC): [Chagga \(FN04\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: 1906-1926

Coverage Date: 1900-1926

Place Coverage: Chagga, Tanzania

Section Title(S): 5. Bride-Transfer And Wedding

Beer was the original offering in legal cases. The intoxication caused by the brew was the first ordeal, the means to determine the truth, the decisive test in a law suit. During a wedding (originally during all sib festivals) the intoxicating drink /i.e. beer—Analyst/ was the mysterious stimulant for the spirit of sib unity. Being intoxicated meant to dive deep down into the strata of origin, the identification with the totemic animal. A clever old Chagga man, who was completely unaware of these speculations, described to me his feelings when he was under the influence of the intoxicating kimanganu drink. He had the feeling as if he had grown to be an elephant... It is easy to imagine what effect the intoxication must have had upon a person whose soul was still cluttered with the fragments of totemic beliefs. In connection with a new marriage it must have appeared very important to them to transfer the old sib strength to the new member... The twin words, wali-wari, lead us back to those motives which we encountered when we approached our subject from another angle.

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I shall be briefer with regard to the other related words. Iduo — carry or lead away; iira — to lift up; yalika — to be under the care. These three words have been mentioned before when we discussed the actions preparatory to the "rest cure" /of the bride before marriage—Analyst/. Yalika is the intransitive variation of yala: to be offered. Cynical translators use the term "to fatten" for it, because the word is used in connection with animals that are stabled in order to be fattened. The natives like to use low jokes in their language.

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Nevertheless, yalika is the best equivalent for the German verb heiraten (to marry). Less frequently used is sembleiana — to become united, derived from sembelya — to come close. Lusebelye mba, for instance, means: we want to sit down together within the house.

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When referred to the bridal pair, mi is the term for the husband and mka for the wife. Mi is a contraction of mili. In the marital instruction songs the husband is often called mile, the e at the end being a lighter ending than the heavier i. Mili 174 can be translated only with "the shining one, the light-

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colored one." It is a bold hypothesis of mine to **153** assume that the word points toward the immigration of light-colored men who were forced to spare the girls of the subjugated race, and who married the girls. This theory, however, is not too fantastic since the Bantu-Negroes are a mixed race with a lighter skin color and more regular facial features than the Negrito proper. The wide variations in skin color among the Chagga points toward the fact that they are a mixture of two extremes and that no equilibrium has been reached between the formative types.

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